

The First Sermon of *Nahj al-balāgha*¹

Praise be to God, whose laudation those who speak cannot deliver, whose graces those who count cannot number, whose rightful due those who strive cannot render; He who cannot be grasped by far-reaching aspirations, nor fathomed by profound intuitions;² He whose attribute has no binding limitation, no existing description, no time appointed, no term extended. Through His power He originated all created things, and through His mercy He diffused the comforting winds;³ and He entrenched with rocky pillars His swaying earth.

Foremost in religion is knowledge of Him,⁴ and the perfection of this knowledge is believing in Him,⁵ and the perfection of this belief is affirming His oneness,⁶ and the perfection of this affirmation is to purify one's devotion to Him,⁷ and the perfection of this purification is to divest Him of all attributes—because of the testimony of every attribute that it is other than the object of attribution, and because of the testimony of every such object that it is other than the attribute.⁸ So whoever ascribes an attribute to God—glorified be He!—has conjoined Him [with something else], and whoever so conjoins Him has made Him twofold, and whoever makes Him twofold has fragmented Him, and whoever thus fragments Him is ignorant of Him. And whoever points to Him confines Him, and whoever confines Him counts Him;⁹ and whoever asks ‘in what?’ encloses Him, and whoever asks ‘upon what?’ isolates Him.¹⁰

Being, but not by way of any becoming; existing, but not from having been non-existent;¹¹ with every thing, but not through association; and other than every thing, but not through separation;¹² acting, but not through movements and instruments; seeing, even when nothing of His creation was to be seen; solitary, even when there was none whose intimacy might be sought or whose absence might be missed.

He brought forth creation, originating it from the very beginning, without pondering over any deliberation or benefiting from any [previous] experience; without initiating any movement or engaging in any unsettling exertion. He assigned to all things their span of time and harmonized their differences; He instilled within them their natural dispositions, impressing upon them their respective forms; knowing them before their genesis, encompassing their boundaries and their finalities; aware of their configurations and their contours.

Then¹³ He—glorified be He!—created a fissure in the atmospheres, cleaving up directions and the uppermost levels of air;¹⁴ then He caused water to flow therein, a current of surging waves, swelling and swirling in overflowing abundance. Then He mounted it upon a tempestuous wind, a thunderous gale; then He made the wind prevent the return of the water, enabling it to dominate the violence of its flow, and aligning it with the boundaries of the water; the air beneath the wind was spread wide open, while the water above it flowed copiously.

Then He raised up a wind, making it sterile,¹⁵ fixing its course, intensifying its current, distancing it from its source. Then he ordered it to agitate the swelling waters and to stir up oceanic waves. The wind churned up the waters—as one churns up milk in a milk-bag—imparting to the water its own violence in the atmosphere, turning its foremost back upon its hindmost, and its stillness to its motion, so that its torrents surged and its swelling waves threw up foam. Then He elevated [the foam] within a cleft air and a vast open atmosphere and formed from it the seven heavens,¹⁶ making the lowest of them a suspended wave and the highest a protected shelter and an elevated ceiling, without any pillars to support them or any clinch to transfix them. Then He adorned the heavens with the ornaments of the stars and the effulgence of the firmament; and made a radiant lamp [the sun] and an illuminating moon to follow an orbit, in a revolving sphere, [beneath] a roof in motion and a firmament in flux.¹⁷

Then He split up the highest heavens and filled them with angels of different dispositions: some prostrating and not bowing; others bowing and not standing upright; some arrayed in ranks, not separating from each other; others glorifying, never wearying—not overcome by sleepiness in the eyes, distraction in the mind, fatigue of the body or the negligence of forgetfulness. And among them are custodians of His Revelation, and conveyors [of His Words] to His Messengers, and those who come and go with His Decree and His Command. And among them are the guardians of His slaves, and the wardens of the gates of His Gardens. And among them are those whose feet stand firmly on the lowest worlds,¹⁸ and whose necks surpass the highest heaven, and whose sides exceed all bounds, and whose shoulders are proportioned to the pillars of the Throne, their eyes cast down before it, enwrapping themselves in their wings beneath it. Between them and all others there is a barrier: veils of Glory and screens of Might. They do not imagine their Lord through formal representation, nor ascribe to Him created attributes; they do not confine Him within places, nor do they allude to Him through similitudes.

Then He—glorified be He!—gathered up a quantity of dust, from some hard earth and some soft, some sweet earth and some salty, and poured water onto it until it was pure,¹⁹ then kneaded into it some moisture until it stuck together; then he fashioned from this a form with curves and joints, limbs and parts. He compacted it until it held tightly together, solidified it until it became as sounding clay,²⁰ assigning to it a measured duration and a known consummation.

Then He breathed into it of His spirit, and it stood up as a human being, endowed with intellectual powers with which to reflect, thoughts by which to conduct himself, limbs to put to service, instruments at his disposal, and knowledge²¹ with which to discern between the true and the false, between different tastes and fragrances, and between different colours and categories; having a constitution compounded of different hues, unified forms, contrasting oppositions, and distinct admixtures of heat and cold, moisture and dryness.

And God—glorified be He!—demanded from the angels the fulfilment of that with which He had charged them, and their compliance with His injunction to them,²² by [ordering] their submissive prostration to him [Adam] and humble reverence of him. So He said, ‘Prostrate to Adam’, and they prostrated, except Iblis. Passionate scorn deranged him, wretchedness overwhelmed him;²³ he prided himself upon [his] constitution of fire and disdained the creature made of clay.²⁴ Then God granted him a respite, that His wrath be fully warranted,²⁵ that the affliction be consummated, and that the promise be fulfilled. So He said, ‘Thou art of those given respite unto a day whose time is appointed’.²⁶

Then He—glorified be He!—settled Adam in an abode wherein He made his life comfortable, and his domain secure; and He warned him of Iblis and his enmity. But his enemy beguiled him, through envious desire for his immortal abode and his intimacy with the righteous. So Adam exchanged certainty for his doubt and resolution for his weakness;²⁷ and replaced joy with dread and self-esteem with remorse. Then God accepted his repentance, and whelmed him with a word from His Mercy and promised him a return to His Garden. Then He made him descend to the abode of tribulations and to the begetting of progeny. And from his offspring He chose prophets, taking from them a pledge in respect of the Revelation, entrusting to them the conveyance of His Message; this, at a time

when most of His creatures had deviated from their covenant with God, so that they ignored His due and set up peers alongside Him, and the demons distracted them from knowledge of Him and sundered them from worship of Him. So He sent amongst them His messengers, dispatching prophets in succession, in order to claim from them [His creatures] the fulfilment of the covenant of His creation;²⁸ to remind them of His forgotten graces; to remonstrate with them through communication [of His Revelation]; to unearth for them the buried treasures of the intellects;²⁹ and to show them signs of omnipotence: the outspread earth laid low beneath them, provisions which give them life, finalities which mete out death; ailments hastening their decrepitude, and a succession of events that flow over them.

And God never deprived His creation of a prophet sent forth, a revealed scripture, an imperative proof or a clear path; messengers who were not diminished by the paucity of their number, nor by the multitude of their deniers. Amongst them, those who came before were told the names of those who would follow them, and those who came after were informed of those who came before.

Thus, generations were begotten and ages elapsed, fathers passing away and sons succeeding them, until God sent forth Muḥammad, Messenger of God, in fulfilment of His promise and completion of His [cycle of] prophecy; he regarding whom a pledge was taken from the prophets,³⁰ renowned through signs, of noble birth. At this time the people on earth were split up into different religious communities; caprice was widespread, pathways were disordered: among them [such paths as] likening God to His creation, distorting His Name, alluding to other than Him. So God guided them through him [the Prophet] out of error and, through his presence, delivered them from their ignorance.

Then He chose for Muḥammad the meeting with Him and desired for him what was with Himself, and removed him with dignity from the abode of the lower world and took him away from any link with [the domain of] trial; so He drew him to Himself honourably. He left behind amongst you that which the prophets leave for their communities, lest they abandon them to stray as they will, without a clear path and a visible beacon: the scripture of your Lord, [the Prophet] clarifying what is lawful and unlawful according to it, the obligatory and the recommended, [verses that] abrogate and [others that are] abrogated therein, the conditionally permissible and the unconditionally compulsory,³¹ the specific and the general,³² His admonitions and analogies, undelimited and delimited [ordinances],³³ unambiguous and equivocal [verses];³⁴ elucidating what is condense and clarifying what is obscure therein.

In it are things knowledge of which is binding upon His slaves, and others, ignorance of which is overlooked; injunctions affirmed as obligatory in the scripture, and known to be abrogated by the *Sunna*; and actions made obligatory by the *Sunna* but abstention from which has been permitted by the scripture; duties incumbent at their prescribed time, but which cease to be so at a later time; [and in it is] the distinction between different forbidden acts, the major ones which He has threatened to punish with His fires, and the minor ones for which He has prepared His forgiveness; [and in it are described] acts that are acceptable when performed to a modest extent, and to a higher degree, without being obligatory.

NOTES

1. As noted in [Chapter 1](#), note 1, this translation of Sermon no.1 is by the present author, based on the critical edition of the *Nahj al-baligha* by Shaykh ‘Azizullāh al-‘Utairi. The final paragraph of the sermon on the subject of pilgrimage, while important in itself, has not been included, as it is not directly related to our discussion in this book.

2. *Alladhī li yudrikuhu bu’d al-himam, wa li yanāluhu ghawḥ; al-fiḥan*. The term *himam*, the plural of *himma*, comprises all kinds of effort, ardour, concentration and intensity in pursuit of a sought after goal. The word *ghawḥ* means depth, *ghāḥa* means to dive deeply into the sea, and *fiḥan* is the plural of *fiḥa*, meaning intelligence, astuteness, sagacity.

3. *Riyālī* (sing. *riḥ*). As Lane notes, the singular form is often used to signify wind in a negative sense, one which brings no good, whereas the plural form often refers to good winds, those that bring rain. The Arabs said that clouds produce rain through diverse winds being blown together. *A ḥadīth* states, ‘O God, make it to be winds and not a wind.’ See Lane, *Lexicon*, vol.1, p. 1181.

4. *Awwalu’l-dīn ma’rifatuḥu*. The word *awwal* literally means ‘the first’ and can be understood as the starting-point, the foundation and hence the foremost element of religion. As for the word *ma’rifa*, as discussed throughout this book, the word denotes not simply knowledge but also ‘recognition’: one comes to know, once again, that which one knew as a seed of consciousness at the dawn of creation: ‘And when thy Lord brought forth from the children of Adam, from their loins, their seed, and made them testify of themselves, “Am I not your Lord?” They said, “Yea, we testify.” [This was] lest ye say on the Day of Resurrection, “Truly of this we were unaware”’ (7: 172).

5. *Kamālu ma’rifatīhi al-taḥḍīqu bihi*. The word *taḥḍīq* is the verbal noun of *ḥaddaqa*, which means to confirm something as true, to give one’s consent or affirmation to it, hence to believe it to be true. The ‘belief’ in question has a dynamic quality about it, connoting the sense of affirming that which one believes—or knows, through the *ma’rifa* referred to as the starting point of religion—to be true.

6. *Kamālu’l-taḥḍīq bihi tawḥīduḥu*. As noted in [Chapter 1](#), the word *tawḥīd*, all too often translated into English as ‘unity’ literally means ‘making one’, and acquires the meaning of affirming or declaring the oneness of God, in theological terms, and realizing (‘making real’) that oneness within one’s consciousness, in spiritual terms.

7. *Kamālu tawḥīdīhi al-ikhlāṣu lahu*.

8. This negation of the attributes should be understood in the light of the earlier phrase, ‘He Whose attribute has no binding limitation (*alladhī laysa li-ḥifātīhi ḥadd malḍūd*).’ So when the Imam says that pure devotion to God (*ikhlāṣ*) requires divesting God of all attributes (*nafyu al-ḥifātī ‘anhu*), the negation here is not of the divine attributes or Names as such, but a negation of them as separate, autonomous or super-added realities, conceived of as being substantially ‘other than’ or ontologically distinct from, the essence of God. This type of apophatic discourse is clearly intended to highlight the utter incommensurability between human *conceptions* of the divine Reality and that Reality *in itself*. See [Chapter 1](#) for discussion of the apophysis here expressed; and [Chapter 3](#) for discussion of the divine attributes in relation to spiritual realization.

9. *Man aḥṣāra ilayhi faqad ḥaddahu; wa man ḥaddahu faqad ‘addahu*. Having pointed to Him, one confines Him to a particular place, marking it off from all other places, thus denying His omnipresence; and having so confined Him, one is able to distinguish between Him and ‘others’ so numbering Him as one among others, and this is a denial of the full ontological meaning of His oneness. See our discussion of this point in [Chapter 1](#).

10. That is, one isolates or removes Him from that which He is not ‘upon’.

11. *Kā’inun li ‘an ḥadathin, mawjūdun li ‘an ‘adamin*. Every existent entity comes into being as the result of a *ḥadath*, that is, a contingent event situated in time and space, on the one hand, and enters into being from a previous state of non-existence, *‘adam*; on the other hand, God indeed ‘is’, but His Being cannot be compared with the being of anything that ‘comes to be’, having once not been. The phrase *‘an ‘adam* might be read as an Arabic foreshadowing of the *creatio ex nihilo*, ‘creation from nothing’, of scholastic theology in the Christian Middle Ages.

12. *Ma ‘a kulli shay’, li bi-muqārana; ghayr kulli shay’, li bi-muzāyala*. As noted in [Chapter 3](#), this sentence can be read as a prefiguration and summary of the doctrine of the ‘oneness of being’ (*walīdat al-wujūd*), associated with the school of Ibn al-‘Arabi.

13. Ibn Abī’l-Ḥadīd comments that the word *thumma*, ‘then’, here should not be read as if it implied a chronological sequence in creation; for what the Imam goes on to describe—the origin of the cosmos—precedes what has been described before—the creation of creatures and forms. It should instead be understood as ‘Now I shall say, after what I have said before...’ *Sharḥ Nahj al-baligha*, vol.1, p. 84.

14. *Ansha ‘a subḥānahu fatqā’l-ajwā’, wa shaqqa’l-arjā’ wa sakā ik al-hawā’*. The word *ajwā’* is the plural of *jaww*, which means air, environment, milieu. The word *arjā’* is the plural of *rajan*, which means the side or direction of a thing, as well as a region or an expanse of space. The image evoked here is that of a cleaving up of the very directions and dimensions of space, dimensions of a vast compass. Thus one finds Ibn Maytham writing that these words refer to the void (*al-khalā’*) out of which an existential space is created, the space within which the primeval water is made to flow, as the Imam goes on to describe. *Sharḥ Ibn Maytham* (Beirut, 1999), vol.1, p. 181. Likewise, in the commentary of ‘Allāma al-Khuṭī, one finds a possible meaning of *al-jaww* as ‘a conceivable dimension’ (*al-bu’d al-mawḥūm*). This is given in the context of his citation of Majlis’s comment on these words in his *Biḥār al-anwār*: ‘What is intended by the words, “He created a fissure in the atmospheres”, is the production of forms within empty spaces.’ *Khuṭī, Minhāj*, vol.1, p. 373.

15. That is, a wind that does not raise rain-producing clouds, nor does it carry pollen; such a wind is called *‘aqīm*.